

**Topic E1: British
Political History,
1945-90:
Consensus and
Conflict**

The main focus of this option is on the key issues which challenged Labour and Conservative governments in the period 1945-90 and the differing and similar ways in which they addressed them. Students are not expected to have detailed knowledge of the composition of governments, but they should develop an understanding of the key features of their domestic policies and achievements in the period. Questions may be set which focus specifically on the roles and importance as prime ministers of Clement Attlee, Harold Macmillan, Harold Wilson, Edward Heath, James Callaghan and Margaret Thatcher. Questions will not be set which focus exclusively on other British political leaders in this period. Since this option is concerned with domestic political history in the period, questions will not be set which focus exclusively and specifically on foreign policy, although students should have knowledge of how foreign policy issues impacted on the fortunes of the two main political parties over the Suez crisis in 1956-7 and over Britain's involvement with the European Economic Community (including the EU) in the years 1957-90. Questions will not be set which focus exclusively and specifically on either Northern Ireland or on Britain's role in decolonisation.

The content bullet points cannot be taken in complete isolation from one another and students should develop an appreciation of links between them. For example, the themes of welfare, housing, education and the handling of the economy can be traced throughout the period 1945-90, drawing on material from all four of the bullet points.

The first bullet point relates to the period of post-war construction under the Labour governments of 1945-51. Students should have knowledge and understanding of why the Labour victory in 1945 was so comprehensive. Although questions will not be set directly on it, students should have contextual awareness of the importance in this period of the Beveridge plan (1942). They should also have knowledge and understanding of the key features of the domestic policy of the Labour governments, including the origins of the National Health Service, nationalisation, the implementation of the Butler Education Act (1944) and policies designed to reduce social inequalities in Britain. The phrase 'an age of austerity' in the specification relates to food rationing and the limited opportunities for leisure and expenditure experienced by most British citizens in the years immediately following the end of the war. Students should be able to consider the impact of Labour policies implemented during this period and the extent of their policies to reduce social inequalities. Students should also have an understanding that the priorities and achievements of the governments were questioned both at the time and later. Students could consider, for example, how far Labour economic policies revealed weaknesses or missed opportunities.

The second bullet point relates to the period of Conservative governments and requires students to explore the extent of continuity with Labour policies and objectives. The key features of the domestic policy of the Conservative governments of 1951-64 concern policies designed to encourage economic expansion, economic development, lower levels of unemployment and increased house-building. Students should also be able to explore the extent to which there was continuity with Labour policies on education and health. Students should be able to explore how far this period did see rising living standards in comparison with the immediate post-war period and be able to account for this difference. Had Britain 'never had it so good' in the 1950s? Why did the situation appear less rosy by the mid 1960s? And what accounts for the Labour election victory of 1964?